SHIFTING TIDES 'The Windmills of the Earth' by Rekha Rodwittiya and (below) a bronze self-portrait by Himmat Shah



ART ▼

Modernism Anew

DAG DELHI'S *FREEDOM TO FORM* EXHIBITION SHOWS HOW BARODA'S FACULTY OF FINE ARTS FORGED AN INDIAN LANGUAGE OF ART

In recent years, Delhi's DAG has organised several shows on the various histories of modernism in Indian art—Santiniketan, the Bengal School, the Madras Art Movement and others. Their latest exhibition in this vein, *Freedom to Form: Baroda Modern*, compiles nearly 200 paintings, sculptures, photographs, prints and mixed-media artworks pertaining to the Baroda Group, artists associated with the Faculty of Fine Arts at the Maharaja Sayajirao University (MSU) of Baroda (established 1949). These include MSU's early teachers like N.S. Bendre, Sankho Chaudhuri, K.G. Subramanyan as well as others like Jyoti Bhatt, Gulammohammed Sheikh, Latika Katt, Jeram Patel et al. The exhibition is accompanied by archival material about everyday life at the Faculty of Fine Arts, plus an eponymous book with essays by Gayatri Sinha, Kanupriya Sharma and others.

From the early days of MSU itself, teachers like K.G. Subramanyan would invite local Baroda craftspeople to the school, in order to give students a first-hand look at the finer points of their skills. This ensured that the future artists of the Baroda Group were learning not just from their professors but also from living, thriving artistic traditions indigenous to the land. Ashish Anand, CEO and MD of DAG, says, "Baroda was India's first art school founded after Independence. Unlike the colonial academies of Calcutta, Bombay and Madras, it inherited no established academic tradition to emulate or reject. Rather than inheriting an academic tradition, the faculty forged a new pedagogical model rooted in experimentation, critical inquiry and sustained engagement with India's visual and craft traditions."

That spirit of versatility is reflected in the sheer variety on display at *Freedom to Form*, where you have the starkness and the exuberance of a Himmat Shah or a Latika Katt sculpture alongside the muted symbolism of Jyoti Bhatt's 'Islands', or the psychedelia of Vivan Sundaram's 'Kites in the Sky'. This is an exhibition that documents a vital strand of modernity in Indian art. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

The show is on till Oct. 24



ART ▶

Nation Building

Ahmed Ali's photographs of post-Independence industry capture the workers who drove India's industrial transformation

As India embarked upon industrialisation after Independence, photographer Ahmed Ali (1923-2016) turned his camera to the people who powered its transformation. *At Work* (1948–1978), presented by PHOTOINK, Delhi, to mark its 25th anniversary, presents the first exhibition

OLD AND NEW **Traditions from Kerala, Punjab, Manipur and more will feature**

